been brought in a prisoner; Nāṣir Mīrzā also is in our hands.’ Babur chose to not respond and ignoring them went towards the hill. They spoke again, but this time, with more respect dismounting from the horse. But despite so, Babur gave no ear to them and went on up a dale till the bedtime prayer, when he reached near a rock as big as a house. He went behind it and found that his horse could go no further. He would need to skip and jump for the way forward. Those two men followed Babur and dismounted again.

They spoke like servants. They said, ‘Where are you going in this manner, without a road, and in the dark? Sulṭān Aḥmad Taṃbal will make you Padishah.’ They swore upon this statement.

Babur replied, ‘My mind is not easy as to that. I cannot go to him. If you think to do me timely service, years may pass before you have such another chance. Guide me to a road by which I can go to the Khān’s presence. If you do this, I will show you favour and kindness greater than your heart’s desire. If you will not do it, go back the way you came; that also will serve me well.’

They replied, ‘Had it not been for Allah, we had never come! But since we are here, after following you in the way we have done, how can we go back from you? If you will not go with us, we are at your service, wherever you go.’

Babur asked, ‘Swear that you speak the truth.’ They nodded and made a solemn oath upon the Qur’an.

Then, Babur at once confided in them, saying, ‘People have shown me a road through a broad valley, somewhere near this glen; take me to it.’[*]

Babur didn’t trust them despite the oath they had taken on the Qur’an, but he decided that nothing could be better than following them in this moment of despair. Having travelled around four miles, Babur and the two men had reached the bed of a torrent. Babur said, ‘This will not be the road for the broad valley.’ They replied, ‘That road is a long way ahead.’ Babur thought in mind that, in reality, this must have been the one we were on, and they were perhaps concealing the fact, to deceive me. About halfway through the night, the three of them reached another stream.

Then they said, ‘We have been negligent; it now seems to us that the road through the broad valley is behind.’

Babur appeared dejected and said, ‘What is to be done?’